

Tunnel Your Way Out

Tunnelling is the process of encapsulating data of one protocol within the data of another, to set up a secure connection.

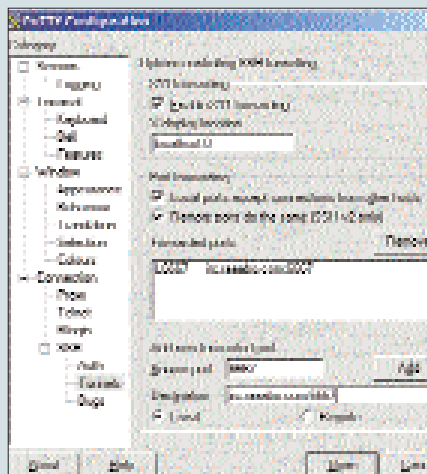
Strictly speaking, tunnelling is frowned upon. So if your office is particularly strict about their Internet access policies, don't do it. For those who work in offices that couldn't care less, and just block ports because every other company does, this can really help.

If you have a Linux machine at home running SSHd, or an account on just about any computer around the world that runs SSHd, you can gain almost unrestricted access to the Internet.

Start PuTTY, enter your home computer's IP address, or the address of the computer you have an account on, check the SSH option and then key in the correct port. Now, in the left-hand pane, go to **Connection > SSH > Tunnels**. If your connection is fast, and the remote computer allows it, you can enable X11 forwarding, otherwise just tunnel so that your applications get access to the ports they use.

The only things you need to know is which applications use which ports, and which servers. For example, to connect to an IRC server (irc.someserver.com, for example) on port 6667, set the source

port to '6667', and the destination to irc.someserver.com:6667. This creates a tunnel as soon as you log in to your home Linux box. Therefore, all you need to do to connect is type `/server 127.0.0.1:6667` in an IRC client. Your IRC client's connection is routed to the remote computer, over your SSH port, to the server you want to connect to. You can do this for all applications that use a specific port, server and the TCP/IP protocol.



You can use PuTTY's port forwarding style tunneling to get access to all that you've been denied, thus far

However, there's one Web site that no one in their right mind would block—Google. The easiest way to surf anonymously is to use Google's cache operator. For example, to view www.thinkdigit.com/forum, all you'd need to do is go to www.google.com and enter 'cache:www.thinkdigit.com/forum' in the search box.

5 Go forth and multiply

Who said you have to have just one desktop? Yes, Linux users have an unfair advantage, as they already have multiple desktops inbuilt with whatever distribution they use, but Windows users, too, can opt for this. You can use Cool Desk, available at http://www.shelltoys.com/virtual_desktop. Install the software, and you're all set. You can create nine virtual desktops, but beware; this uses a lot of system resources.

All you need is two desktops: one for all non-work related applications, and the other for stuff that your boss expects to see you working with. Switch to the one with all the work-related applications at the slightest sign of boss trouble.

4 SSH! He can hear everything

For those who run Linux, are lucky enough to have an always-on broadband connection at home, and unlucky enough to work in an office where just about every port is blocked, you can make a monkey out of everyone.

All you need to do is run SSHd (Secure Shell daemon) on your Linux box at home, set it to accept incoming connections from a port that your office allows (port 80 for example), and leave your home PC running when you're at work.

Now you can use an SSH client such as PuTTY to access the Internet, and do just about anything you want. You can even use PuTTY's X11 forwarding to use the GUI, and its tunnelling capabilities to forward ports (See box 'Tunnel Your Way Out' above).

Remember, you can also use this even if you have just a shell account on a Linux box anywhere in the world, with unrestricted Internet access.

If You Can't Beat 'Em, Join 'Em

Not all bosses are born that way! Most were human once, and even employed some of the tactics mentioned in this article to pull the wool over *their* superiors' eyes. Here's what the experts had to say:

“ Cell phones make certain noises called 'ring tones'. These are handy when you're in a meeting, and can't suppress a yawn. Just get your cell phone to ring, make it sound like the company's fate depends on this call, excuse yourself, and take five minutes to compose yourself before returning to the ordeal. ”

Prashant Narekuli,
Brand Manager, Digit

“ I use two separate branches of my work to make excuses for each other. So when management calls me for a meeting, I tell them I'm busy with editorial work, and vice-versa. I also use "editor-powers" to worm out of meetings. ”

Sumod Hajela,
Assistant Editor

“ I always keep three windows open—the New York Times Technology Web site, the CNN tech page and the Google news page. This way, my boss thinks I am researching all the time. What he doesn't know that there is a word game always on in the background. ”

Sachin Kalbag,
Features Editor

“ We use *Quake III* to test graphic cards, PCs, motherboards, CPUs and laptops! We *Quake*, and if anyone asks, we claim to be testing Intel's latest CPU—when actually the CPU is some old P3! This is so clichéd now, people think we're goofing off even when we're actually testing! ”

Deepak Dhingra,
Assistant Manager, Test Centre

“ If you stand around chatting with your colleagues, it's wise to blurt out a few official sounding words now and then—even if it's out of context. So we stand around chatting all day, and slip in words such as 'layout', 'pagination', 'illustration', 'photo-shoot', etc., just in case a senior is within earshot. ”

G S Viridi
Editor, Smart Computing